

Understanding Game Ratings

When you're buying games – be it for your kids or for yourself – the game ratings on the packaging let you know what to expect from them in terms of content. If you don't want to be shocked yourself, or let your kids play stuff you don't them going near, get clued in on the different standards and game ratings you're likely to encounter.

ESRB

The Entertainment Software Rating Board is a self-regulatory organisation that issues ratings for games and entertainment software that are released in the United States, Canada and Mexico. This is also the rating system that appears most frequently at the beginning of video game trailers and previews on the internet.

Ratings:

The ESRB uses letters for its ratings.



These games have pretty much no offensive content and are safe to be played by very young children. Educational games and games featuring characters like Nemo and Winnie the

Pooh usually fall under this rating.



Games rated E might contain extremely limited cartoon violence, if at all, and are hence safe for most kids to play. Most sports games and sim racers fall under this category, as do franchises like

Mario and Little Big Planet.



As the name implies, these games are considered unsuitable for children under 10 years of age to play because of mildly suggestive themes, the possible inclusion of

blood, violence and mild

language. Think of it as the video game equivalent of the Parental Guidance rating for movies and TV shows.



Considered safe for people aged 13 or more, this rating is given to games that feature a lot more violence, suggestive themes, gambling or rare use of mild language.

Recent examples of games

with this rating include the Uncharted series and Batman: Arkham Asylum.



These games are very likely to have copious amounts of sexual themes, blood, violence or foul language. Several US retailers require Age Identification to sell games with this rating to

people, something that is not followed here, so be on your toes. Call of Duty, Halo and Grand Theft Auto games fall under this category.



A no-brainer, these games are only to be played by adults. Expect nudity, extreme violence or excessive foul language. These games are extremely rare

though, because console manufacturers usually don't allow games rated AO to be published on their platforms. GTA: San Andreas and Manhunt 2 were toned down once threatened with this rating.



Games under this category have been submitted to the ESRB for rating, but don't have one yet. This is usually only found in pre-release promotional material like trailers and ads. Once rated,

the material has to be changed to reflect the actual rating.

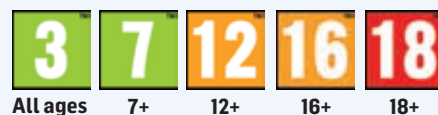
PEGI

The Pan European Game Information rating covers games released in Europe, and are the

ratings you're most likely to encounter here in India, because we fall under the PAL region for video games.

Ratings:

PEGI uses five age categories and eight images that describe in-game content. The age categories are self-explanatory, really.



Descriptions:

In addition to the age ratings, PEGI also provides content descriptions in the form of eight images that make it onto the packaging if that type of content is present in the game.



Violence, blood and death



Profanity and general Bad Language



Disturbing or frightening images



Sexual attraction, intercourse, suggestive clothing or nudity



Illegal drugs or fictional equivalents



Includes betting of virtual money



Discrimination on the basis of race, ethnicity, gender or sexual preferences



Contains online game-play, the experience of which usually doesn't factor into the age rating

CERO

One of the two organisations that rates video games in Japan, CERO only rates games released on consoles. Its ratings are based on alphabetic levels, in a manner much like ESRB's. The five levels are **A** (all ages), **B** (12 and above), **C** (15 and above), **D** (17 and above) and **Z** (18 and above only).